

HISTORY OF CONTEMPORARY WORLDS, XX-XXI CENTURIES

Academic year 2025/2026 – Spring semester

Lecturer: Professor Pierre Fuller pierre.fuller@sciencespo.fr

Discussion section instructor: Yuqing Qiu yuqing.qiu@sciencespo.fr

COURSE DESCRIPTION

Discussion sessions complement the lecture course by dwelling on the main issues addressed by Prof. Fuller. The weekly two-hour seminar will provide a platform for students to deepen their knowledge of major topics related to 20th century history by engaging in class discussions, written assignments and oral presentations.

GRADING

- ★ Discussion Section ($\frac{2}{3}$):
 - Analysis of a primary source in class (25%)
 - Oral presentations (25%)
 - Midterm Essay (40%)
 - Oral participation (10%)
- ★ Final exam ($\frac{1}{3}$)

NB:

Analysis of a primary source comprises 25% of your course grade and will take place in class.

Oral presentations comprise 25% of your course grade. Presentation dates will be assigned at the start of the semester to coincide with topics under consideration.

a.) The 12- to 15-minutes individual oral presentation should provide the class with an in-depth examination of an article-based given subject.

b.) This exercise should help you familiarize with the readings and enable you to use the main concepts developed during the lecture. You should send me the outline and draft presentation slides before NOON every Wednesday to yuqing.qiu@sciencespo.fr.

Oral participation will be evaluated on attendance and constructive participation in section

a). **Attendance** at all sections is required. If you will be absent due to illness, please send me an email before the section starts. Unexcused absences will influence your oral participation grade.

b). **Expectation of in-class participation** consists of thoughtful contributions to our discussion. Discussion should be but not limited to materials from the readings. The classroom is a SAFE PLACE for ideas, discussion and debates.

Midterm and Final exams will be based on the lectures, seminar contents and discussions, and on the studying of the documents. Complementary readings by the students will of course be necessary. Unless the teaching conditions change because of a worsening of the sanitary situation, both exams will be timed and tabled.

Anti-plagiarism policy

Plagiarism is not tolerated. All cases of plagiarism will be reported to campus advisers and sanctioned. Penalties for plagiarism range from the grade of zero to non-validation of the course and suspension. To learn more about Sciences Po anti-plagiarism policy please visit [the following page](#) and read the [anti-plagiarism regulation](#).

Policy regarding the use of AI applications

The use of ChatGPT, or any other tool using AI is forbidden in both written and oral academic works and will be immediately reported to the direction of the campus.

SYLLABUS

Session 1 – Course Introduction: The World at 1900 (January 29)

Documents:

- “Twelve People Look at the Twentieth Century,” from Eric Hobsbawm, *Age of Extremes: The Short Twentieth Century, 1914-1991*. London: Michael Joseph, 1994.

TASKS

- Methodology point 1. How to give a successful presentation?
- Distribution of presentation topics
- Class representative election

Session 2 – WWI in Europe and Asia (February 5)

Documents:

- Annette Becker, “The Great War: World war, total war,” *International Review of the Red Cross* 97/900 (2015).
- Primary source: Emmeline Pankhurst, “The plight of women” (London, 1908) and “Freedom or death” (Hartford, Connecticut, 1913)
- Suggested podcast: “Dispatches from 1918,” Radiolab (WNYC)

TASKS:

- Presentations:
 - Nostalgia and the Old Empire: A history of emotions
 - Steven Beller, “The World of Yesterday Revisited: Nostalgia, Memory and the Jews of Fin-de-siècle Vienna,” *Jewish Social Studies*, vol.2 (2) (1996), p.37-53.
 - The Making of Modern Refugees
 - Peter Gatrell, “War, Refugeedom, Revolution: Understanding Russia’s refugee crisis, 1914-1918,” *Cahiers du monde russe*, vol. 58 (1-2) (2017), p. 124-145.

- Methodology point 2: How to read a text in a corpus?

Session 3 – The 1920s: Leninism, Taylorism & the League of Nations (February 12)

Documents:

- Eric D. Weitz, “From the Vienna to the Paris System: International Politics and the Entangled Histories of Human Rights, Forced Deportations, and Civilizing Missions,” *The American Historical Review* 113/5 (Dec., 2008), 1313-1343.

TASKS:

- Presentations:
 - Humanitarianism and Imperial Legacies:
 - Tehila Sasson, “From Empire to Humanity: The Russian Famine and the Imperial Origins of International Humanitarianism,” *Journal of British Studies*, vol.55, no. 3 (2016), p. 519-37.
 - Did Hunger Create Global Governance?
 - Patricia Clavin, “The Austrian hunger crisis and the genesis of international organization after the First World War,” *International Affairs*, vol.90 (2)(2014), p. 265-278.

Session 4 – The 1930s: Depression & Rising Tensions (February 19)

Documents:

- Ralph Thaxton, “State Making and State Terror: The Formation of the Revenue Police and the Origins of Collective Protest in Rural North China during the Republican Period,” *Theory and Society* (June 1990), 335-376.
- Primary source: Franklin Delano Roosevelt, “The forces of selfishness and of lust for power met their match” (New York, 1936).

TASKS:

- Presentations:
 - Communism and Nationalism
 - Martin Mevius, “Reappraising Communism and Nationalism,” *The Journal of Nationalism and Ethnicity*, vol. 37 (4) (2009), p. 377-400.
 - How did Fascism conceive of the relationship between human beings and nature?
 - Patrizia Dogliani. “Environment and Leisure in Italy during Fascism,” *Modern Italy*, vol.19 (3) (2014), p. 247-259.

- Race, Empire and the Global 1930s
 - Vivian Kong, “Whiteness, Imperial Anxiety, and the ‘Global 1930s’: The White British League Debate in Hong Kong,” *Journal of British Studies*, 59(2) (2020), p. 343-371.
- Methodology point 3. How to write an introduction?

Session 5 – WWII: Fascism & the Greater East Asia Co-Prosperity Sphere (February 26)

Documents:

- Ian Kershaw, “Hitler and the Uniqueness of Nazism,” *Journal of Contemporary History* 39/2 (2004).
- Primary source: Mao Zedong, “The Bankruptcy of the Idealist Conception of History” (1949).

TASKS:

- Presentations:
 - How did the NSDAP developed into a nationwide Nazi movement in Weimar Berlin?
 - Kjøstvedt, Anders G. “The Dynamics of Mobilisation: The Nazi Movement in Weimar Berlin,” *Politics, Religion & Ideology*, vol.14 (3) (2013), p. 338-354.
 - Memory in Postwar Asia: Memories of Empire in the Cold War Japan
 - Sebastian Conrad, “The Dialectics of Remembrance: Memories of Empire in Cold War Japan”, *Comparative Studies in Society and History*, vol. 56 (1) (2014), p. 4-33.

Session 6 – Decolonization, Modernization Theory & the Green Revolution: 1950s (March 5)

Documents:

- Sigrid Schmalzer, *Introduction*, pp 1-26 from *Red Revolution, Green Revolution: Scientific Farming in Socialist China*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2016.
- Frantz Fanon, “Colonial War and Mental Disorders” & “Case No. 5,” pp 249-254 & 267-270 from *The Wretched of the Earth* (original *Les Damnés de la Terre*. Paris: François Maspero, 1961).

TASKS:

- Presentations:
 - What was the role of diplomacy played in the Bandung Conference 1955?
 - Naomi Shimazu. "Diplomacy as Theatre: Staging the Bandung Conference of 1955". *Modern Asian Studies*, vol.46, No. 1, 2014, pp.225-252.
 - Korea: Decolonization, Civil War and Cold War (1945-1953)
 - Lorri Watt. "Embracing Defeat in Seoul: Rethinking Decolonization in Korea, 1945", *The Journal of Asian Studies*, vol.74 (1) (2015), p. 497-532.
- Methodology point 4: How to make a good outline?

Session 7 – Counterculture & Cultural Revolution: 1968 (March 12)

Documents:

- Thomas Frank, "Think Young: Youth Culture and Creativity," pp 105-130 from *The Conquest of Cool: Business Culture, Counterculture, and the Rise of Hip Consumerism*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1997.

TASKS:

- Presentations:
 - What is the legacy of Youth Movement in the 1968?
 - Richard Ivan Jobs, "Youth Movements, Travel, Protests, and Europe in 1968.", *The American Historical Review*, vol.114 (2) (2009), p. 376-404.
 - A Cold War in a Cold War? The Sino-Soviet rivalry (1960-1979)
 - Richard Lowenthal, "Russia and China: Controlled Conflict," *Foreign Affairs*, vol. 49 (3) (1971), p. 507-518.

Session 8 – A Cooling Cold War: 1970s & 1980s (March 19)

Documents:

- Sunil Amrith, "Burning Forests," pp 275-296 from *The Burning Earth: An Environmental History of the Last 500 Years*. London: Allen Lane, 2024.
- Primary source: TBD.

TASKS

- Presentations:
 - Global Feminism

- Kristen Ghodsee, “Rethinking State Socialist Mass Women’s Organizations: The Committee of the Bulgarian Women’s Movement and the United Nations Decade for Women, 1975-1985,” *Journal of Women’s History*, vol. 24 (4) (2012), p. 49-73.
- Informal Actors and Sino-U.S. Rapprochement
- Gong Bingyi and Kazushi Minami, “From Imperialists to Pacifists: American Quakers and US-China Relations in the Cold War,” *Cold War History*, vol. 26 (1) (2003), p. 1–20.

Session 9 – Globalization & “War on Terror”: 1990s & 2000s (March 26)

Documents:

- Anne Allison, “Enchanted Commodities,” pp 1-34 from *Millennial Monsters: Japanese Toys and the Global Imagination*. Berkeley: University of California Press, 2006.
- Primary source: *Arundhati Roy, preface to The Cost of Living*. New York: The Modern Library, 1999.

TASKS:

- Presentations:
 - A Catalyst for Change: Glasnost and Perestroika in Eastern Europe
 - David S. Mason, “Glasnost, Perestroika and Eastern Europe.” *International Affairs (Royal Institute of International Affairs 1944-)*, vol.64 (3) (1988), p. 431-48.
- Media and Social Protest
 - Pat Proctor, “Message versus Perception during the Americanization of the Vietnam War,” *The Historian*, vol. 73 (1) (2011), p. 88-11.

Session 10 – Systemic Crisis & Fallout: 2010s (April 2)

Documents:

- Cédric Durand, “Introduction: The Sign of Autumn” and “Epilogue,” from *Fictitious Capital: How Finance Appropriates Our Future*. London: Verso, 2017 (original version: *Le Capital fictive*, 2014).
- Primary source: TBD.

TASKS:

- Presentations:
 - Development and Underdevelopment in the Modern World
 - Alice Amsden, “Third World Industrialization: ‘Global Fordism’ or a New Model”, *New Left Review*, vol. 182 (1990), p. 5-31.
 - For or against Amsden?
 - Eloisa Betti. “Gender and Precarious Labor in a Historical Perspective: Italian Women and Precarious Work between Fordism and Post-Fordism,” *International Labor and Working Class History*, vol.89 (2016), p.64-83.

Session 11 – Pandemic, Climate Crisis & Trumpism: 2020s (April 9)

Documents:

- Amitav Ghosh, “War by Another Name,” pp 163-171 from *The Nutmegs Curse: Parables for a Planet in Crisis*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2021.

TASKS:

- Presentations:
 - The Politics of Borders
 - Laura Velasco Ortiz and Oscar Contreras, “The Border as a Life Experience: Identities, Asymmetry and Border Crossing between Mexico and the United States,” *Frontera Norte* 26 (2014), p. 37-56.
 - Rethinking the U.N. in War
 - Thomas G.Weiss and Amir Pasic, “Reinventing UNHCR: Enterprising Humanitarians in the Former Yugoslavia, 1991–1995,” *Global Governance*, vol. 3 (1) (1997), p. 41-57.

Session 12 – Conclusions: Looking Backward, Looking Forward (April 18)

No readings.

TASKS:

- Final exam prep.